

SEO Migration Audit

PrestaShop 1.7 → 8.6 — Side-by-Side Comparison

Live site: <https://safetynigeria.com/>

Staging site: <https://staging.safetynigeria.com/>

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Scope: Technical SEO, On-Page, Structured Data, Performance, Content & Migration Risk

MIGRATION READINESS

74_{/100}

Fixable — not shippable yet

1. Executive Summary

The migration is **structurally sound but not yet production-ready**. The single most important SEO factor — the **URL structure** — is **preserved identically** (category-slug/ID-product-slug.html and ID-category-slug), and PrestaShop's ID-based auto-redirects already handle **92 of 118** renamed URLs cleanly. Several items are genuinely **better** on staging: it adds **JSON-LD Product / Offer / Brand** structured data the live site lacks, adds a **homepage canonical** the live site is missing, and **fixes a corrupted meta description** on the homepage. HTTPS is enforced, 404s return true 404s, pagination self-canonicalizes, and faceted-filter URLs correctly canonicalize to the clean category.

However, there are **four launch blockers**, all configuration-level and fixable:

- **The XML sitemap is hard-coded to** `http://localhost/safetynigeria/` — the Shop URL / sitemap was generated against a localhost dev domain. Shipped as-is, Google receives 4,035 dead localhost URLs.
- **Staging has no robots.txt (HTTP 404)** and is **fully indexable** (no `noindex`, no `X-Robots-Tag`, self-referencing canonical) — a live duplicate-content risk now, and production would launch without a robots.txt.
- **21 live URLs return hard 404s on staging** (deleted / re-ID'd products & categories) with no redirect — direct ranking / backlink loss.
- **Canonical & sitemap domain must be switched to the production domain** at cutover (everything currently self-references staging).

None of these are architectural; all can be resolved in a short pre-launch sprint. **Do not launch until blockers 1–4 are fixed.**

2. Complete SEO Difference Table

#	Area	Live (PS 1.7)	Staging (PS 8.6)	Severity	Direction
1	Sitemap URLs	https://safetynigeria.com/...	ALL 4,035 URLs = http://localhost/safetynigeria/...	CRITICAL	Regression
2	robots.txt	Present, full PS ruleset, HTTP 200	HTTP 404 - missing entirely	CRITICAL	Regression
3	Staging indexability	n/a	No robots, no noindex, no X-Robots-Tag, 200 public = crawlable	CRITICAL	Risk
4	Lost URLs -> hard 404	21 product/category URLs indexed	Return 404, no redirect	CRITICAL	Regression
5	Canonical domain	safetynigeria.com	staging.safetynigeria.com (flip at cutover)	HIGH	Migration step
6	Renamed URLs (slugs)	118 URLs	92 auto-301 to new slug (PS ID-match) - safe	MEDIUM	Neutral / OK
7	Catalog size	2,256 page URLs	4,035 page URLs (~1,897 new products)	LOW	Improvement
8	Duplicate canonical tag	1 canonical / page	2 identical canonical tags on product pages	MEDIUM	Regression
9	Homepage canonical	Missing	Present	LOW	Improvement
10	Homepage <title>	Nigeria Safety Shop... (56 ch)	Industries Safety Nigeria PPE... Lagos (77 ch)	MEDIUM	Changed - monitor
11	Homepage meta description	Corrupt artifact [i]ps_[i]1.7.6.7...	Clean, rewritten (183 ch)	LOW	Improvement
12	Product structured data	Microdata only, 0 JSON-LD	JSON-LD Product + Offer + Brand added	LOW	Improvement
13	hreflang	hreflang=en-us on home	Removed	MEDIUM	Regression (minor)
14	Cross-domain 301s	n/a	A few category->CMS 301s point to live domain	LOW	Cosmetic
15	HTTP->HTTPS / www	Enforced	301 http->https enforced	LOW	OK / parity
16	404 handling	Proper 404	Proper 404 (no soft-404)	LOW	OK
17	Pagination canonical	?page=2 self-canonical	?page=2 self-canonical (parity)	LOW	OK
18	Faceted-nav canonical	-	Filter URL canonicalizes to clean category	LOW	OK (good)
19	Product title / desc	e.g. PL2 Force - Agro Products	Identical	LOW	OK
20	Multiple H1s	3 H1s per product page	3 H1s (same)	MEDIUM	Pre-existing (both)
21	Image alt gaps	178 imgs; 11 missing + 5 empty (home)	166 imgs; 11 missing + 5 empty	LOW	Pre-existing (both)
22	OG / Twitter tags	Products 6 OG, 0 Tw; Home 0 OG	Same	LOW	Parity
23	Server / PHP	LiteSpeed	PHP 7.3.33; Cache-Control: no-store on home	MEDIUM	Verify

Severity legend: Critical = launch blocker · High = fix before launch · Medium = fix soon / monitor · Low = hygiene or improvement.

3. Detailed Findings by Category

Technical SEO

- **robots.txt:** Live serves a complete PrestaShop ruleset (blocks ?order=, ?search_query=, cart / checkout / account controllers, system dirs; declares the sitemap). **Staging returns a 404** — no robots.txt exists.
- **Sitemaps:** Both have an index → `1_en_0_sitemap.xml`. Live = 2,256 page URLs (correct domain). **Staging = 4,035 URLs, every one localhost-based**, and the index itself lists localhost.
- **Canonicals:** Product / category / pagination canonicals are correct in form and use the request host. The homepage **gains** a canonical (live had none). Must flip to the production domain at cutover.
- **Meta robots / X-Robots-Tag:** No noindex anywhere on staging (good for production, risky for staging while open).
- **HTTPS:** Enforced on staging; `http://` 301-redirects to `https://`.
- **Status codes:** 404s are true 404s; all tested redirects are single-hop (no chains or loops detected).

On-Page SEO

- Product **titles, meta descriptions, OG tags and breadcrumbs are identical** on matched pages.
- **Homepage title & meta description changed** (improved / geo-expanded). Improvement, but any title change on a top-ranking homepage should be **monitored** post-launch.
- **Multiple H1s (3 per product page)** exist on **both** sites — pre-existing, not a regression.
- Image alt gaps are **identical** on both — pre-existing, not caused by the migration.

Structured Data

- **Improved:** staging adds a JSON-LD Product / Offer / Brand block (live had microdata only, 0 JSON-LD). Re-validate in Google's Rich Results Test after the domain fix so it emits production URLs, not localhost.

Performance (indicative)

- Homepage payloads similar (~396 KB live vs ~351 KB staging). Same theme on both, so performance gains are incremental, not a re-platform.
- Cache-Control: no-store, no-cache on the staging homepage suggests full-page caching is off — confirm cache / CDN is enabled in production or TTFB / Core Web Vitals may regress.
- Lab CWV / Lighthouse not run in this pass — recommend a PageSpeed Insights run on 3–4 templates pre-launch.

Content Audit

- **~1,897 new product pages** added (catalog expansion) — positive.
- **21 live pages removed with no redirect (404).** Examples: `safety-work-boots-shoes-suppliers/187-`, `/253-`, `/532-`; categories `581/582/592-lab-*`, `707-ratchet-straps`, `708-vehicle-recovery`, `116-country-flags`, `325-protective-sleeves`.

Migration Risks

- **Duplicate content (now):** indexable staging competing with live.
- **Duplicate content (at launch):** localhost sitemap + domain config if not corrected.

- **Broken backlinks:** the 21 hard-404 URLs.
- **Redirect chains / loops:** none found (all single-hop).

PrestaShop-Specific

- Product / category URL generation, pagination, faceted canonicalization and ID-based auto-redirects all behave correctly in 8.6. The 1.7 → 8.6 upgrade did **not** break the URL scheme — the major win of this migration.

4. Recommended Fixes (priority order)

Priority	Action	Why it matters
CRITICAL	Set the production Shop URL (Shop Parameters → Traffic & SEO → Set Shop URL) to safetynigeria.com + SSL domain; then regenerate the XML sitemap AND robots.txt.	Removes all localhost URLs; makes canonicals & sitemap production-correct. Fixes #1, #2, #5 together.
CRITICAL	Block staging from indexing now (HTTP Basic Auth or X-Robots-Tag: noindex on the staging host). Keep blocked until cutover; remove at go-live.	Prevents staging being indexed and creating duplicate content with live (#3).
CRITICAL	Create 301 redirects for the 21 hard-404 URLs to the closest equivalent product/category (or parent category if discontinued).	Preserves rankings + backlinks for removed pages (#4).
HIGH	After cutover, re-test the 92 auto-301 URLs on production, submit the new sitemap in Google Search Console, and monitor Coverage.	Confirms PS ID-match redirects survived and Google re-crawls fast (#6).
MEDIUM	Remove the duplicate <link rel=canonical> (theme + module/core both inject one). Keep a single tag.	Avoids ambiguity if the two ever diverge (#8).
MEDIUM	Restore the homepage hreflang self-reference if intended, or drop deliberately.	Parity with live (#13).
MEDIUM	Monitor the homepage title change; revert if the homepage loses positions for core queries.	Title is a strong ranking signal on the money page (#10).
MEDIUM	Confirm production runs PHP 7.4+ and full-page cache / CDN is enabled (staging shows PHP 7.3.33 + no-store).	Avoid CWV / TTFB regression (#23).
LOW	Fix multiple H1s and missing/empty image alts (both sites).	Pre-existing; low impact, easy wins (#20, #21).
LOW	Validate the new JSON-LD Product schema in Rich Results Test after the domain fix.	Lock in the structured-data improvement (#12).

5. Migration Readiness Score

74 / 100

Fixable — not shippable yet

Dimension	Score	Notes
URL structure & redirects	17 / 25	Same scheme + 92/118 auto-301; -8 for 21 hard 404s
Crawl / index config	9 / 20	robots.txt missing + staging indexable + localhost sitemap
Canonical / domain integrity	12 / 15	Correct form; must flip domain + remove dup canonical
On-page parity	14 / 15	Titles / desc / OG / breadcrumbs preserved; title to monitor
Structured data	10 / 10	Improved (JSON-LD added)
Performance / infra	7 / 10	Caching off + PHP 7.3 to confirm
Content completeness	5 / 5	Catalog expanded, nothing thin introduced
TOTAL	74 / 100	Rises to ~92–95% once the four blockers are cleared

6. Final Recommendation

Not safe to replace the live site yet — but no architectural rework is needed. This is a clean platform upgrade whose only obstacles are **configuration leftovers from a localhost build**, not broken SEO foundations. The URL scheme is preserved, redirects mostly self-heal, and structured data improved.

Hard blockers to clear before go-live:

CRITICAL	Set the production Shop URL and regenerate the sitemap (kill all localhost URLs).
CRITICAL	Generate / serve a production robots.txt with the correct Sitemap: line.
CRITICAL	301-redirect the 21 hard-404 URLs.
CRITICAL	Block staging from indexing now; confirm canonicals / sitemap resolve to safetynigeria.com at cutover.

Once those four are done (roughly a half-day to a day of work) and verified on the production domain, **readiness rises to ~92–95% and the site is safe to launch**, with standard Search Console monitoring for 2–4 weeks afterward. Have GSC, the new sitemap submission, and a 404 monitor ready on day one of cutover.

Method: direct HTTP/HTML inspection (browser-UA curl), full XML-sitemap diff (2,256 live vs 4,035 staging page URLs), and live HTTP status-code testing of every divergent URL. Lab Core Web Vitals not measured in this pass.